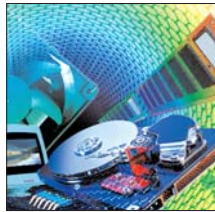


32 Enter The Matrix!



40 Tube Tech



46 Sonic Boom

Digital

Passion

Fuelling The Pursuit Of Technology Knowledge

Cover Story

Are We There Yet?

Even with prices falling, you still pay more for your bandwidth than you should. What's going on, and will 2007 really be the "year of broadband"?

Nimish Chandiramani

"Hey, watch this hilarious video", says the friend from the US, and you click on the YouTube link with all imaginable anticipation. "It's still loading," you say, when said friend asks you whether you watched it. Now, if your US-based friends are anything like ours, they'll instantly give in to the temptation to send you a screenshot of their 500 KBps (yes, that's kilo bytes) download and call it Awww.jpg.

The urban Indian's quest for high-speed Internet access is something that should be turned into a daily soap—lots of tears, and with nothing of note happening over long periods of time. There isn't a rant about broadband connections we haven't heard; what ulterior motive could ISPs have for not giving us our daily GB? After all, depriving customers isn't exactly smart business, is it? But before we get on, time for a little lesson...

The Bandwidth Food Chain

This whole explanation becomes simpler if you consider bandwidth to be a commodity—like apples, for example. It all starts with the Network Service Providers (NSPs), who own the backbone to the Internet. They're the ones bringing bandwidth to India, and selling it to both ISPs and you. Bharti (Airtel), Reliance, VSNL, MTNL, and BSNL, for example, are all NSPs—they're the people importing the apples.

Next are the ISPs, who buy bandwidth by the GB from the NSPs—usually more than one—and sell it to you. Just like the supermarkets that stock the imported apples. And just like you're charged for apples by quality and quantity, ISPs are charged for speed and data transfer—which is why they need to cap your connections as well. There are two types of ISPs—those who have established their own infrastructure and provide access over that, and those who use infrastructure that already exists—Sify, for example, provides its broadband services over the cable that has already been laid out by your local cable operator. Both deal with their own advantages and disadvantages—

